sandwiches and samosas in the solarium or in the library or in the Chinese room'. She was so meticulous in her ways that she would send a slip to her chauffeur about her travel programme well in advance and inform him whether she would prefer to travel in her Rolls-Royce or Delage that day. To ensure she left at the appointed time, she would send another note to her British house help to inform her what time she should be ready to assist Lady Tata.

Ratan also imbibed from his grandmother the humility and the courage to graciously admit to mistakes. He learned that such behaviour costs nothing; it is not demeaning but a strength. Lady Tata had no qualms about apologizing even in public for any mistake she may have made. Ratan recalls a time when his grandmother did not bat an eyelid and apologized to her cook when she realized that she had mistakenly faulted him. She would not shy away from apologizing even to her grandson if she realized she was in the wrong. In such situations, she would write a small note saying, 'I'm sorry', and slip it under his door. Ratan too finds it important to say sorry if he is at fault, irrespective of the person he has to say it to.

Lady Tata's empathy for the poor and her earnestness to alleviate their suffering left a lasting impression upon Ratan. During her lifetime, she occupied various important positions. She was the first woman to be a trustee of the Parsi Panchayat and the only woman director of Tata Sons. As the chairperson of the Sir Ratan Tata Trust and a trustee of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust, Lady Tata extended help to many organizations involved in training women and girls in trade and was instrumental in setting up the Arty Toys Industrial Institute to help differently abled persons to earn a livelihood. Her emphasis was on creating opportunities for the underprivileged to empower themselves and earn a living. This philosophy of philanthropy still largely guides Ratan, the chairman of Tata Trusts.

Choosing a Profession

After Ratan completed his Senior Cambridge examination, he had to figure out the further education he would choose and the country in which he would pursue it. Like many fathers of that era, Naval expected his son to follow in his footsteps. He made no secret of his desire that Ratan should complete his graduation in India, pursue an articleship in the UK and return as a chartered accountant. But Ratan's heart was lost to architecture. He